think of various alternative Furrys doing different things, but I cannot think of a non-denumerable [infinity] of alternative Furrys." The conference continued, and Everett's ideas were discussed with genuine interest for the remainder. But other than the small group of attendees, nobody knew what had happened: the proceedings remained publicly unavailable for the next forty years (by which point everyone who had been present, aside from Aharonov and one or two others, was dead).

Everett's theory slipped into a deep obscurity for the next decade, provoking almost no immediate reaction—certainly not the kind of fierce backlash that Bohm's papers had prompted. The universal wave function was simply ignored for years, while Everett himself hid in plain sight as a cold warrior. Occasionally the idea would come up in conversation with one of his physicist–turned–war-gamer colleagues; when it did, Everett was reluctant to talk about it, and he never took the debate to a larger arena. He was a dark jester, amused by paradox, perverse arguments, and private jokes. The wider stage of academia held no allure for him—and, anyhow, he didn't like public speaking. He felt no particular need to remedy the physics community's misguided manner of thinking about quantum physics. That task would take a different sort of person: not just an academic but someone with a stronger sense of moral obligation and integrity, someone who didn't mind voicing unpopular opinions on a large stage, someone who could speak and write compellingly and who understood exactly how to approach the problems at hand in a way that other physicists would pay attention to. It took someone who had always known Copenhagen was rotten, who had seen David Bohm do the impossible. It took a person like John Stewart Bell.